

Some Linux with that?

The 2.6.x kernel release brings a faster GUI, in tow with Advanced Linux Sound Architecture (ALSA) support, amongst other goodies.

Hot on its heels, is the 3.2 release of the KDE desktop environment system, with improved speed, better cross-application integration and a cleaner menu structure. The team behind Gnome is also at work at a 2.5.x release. One finds that its Nautilus file manager now supports spatial browsing; also seen are audio-



mixers using ALSA and a few tweaks to the Epiphany browser. This release branch is on its 2.5.5 Development Release however, so a usable version is some ways off.

IBM has announced its intent to migrate Microsoft's Office suite to Linux. Microsoft however, denied any involvement, stating that IBM is going solo on this ride, further stating that no source code has exchanged hands to facilitate such a transition.

An OLED to displays

An organic LED (OLED) is made of semi-conducting organic polymers and is cheaper to fabricate. An OLED display doesn't require a backlight and draws far less power.

A market research company, iSuppli, offers that OLED displays are becoming a credible alternative. The Inquirer (www.theinquirer.net) quoted Kimberly Alton, director strategic research at iSuppli, from a report called Emerging Displays Review. Kyocera will develop colour passive and a-Si-based active OLEDs. Chi Mei, ID Tech and IBM demonstrated a 20-inch OLED panel. Sony will commercialise an OLED-based panel in spring this year.

Showdown after sundown

Bluetooth has a serious contender. At the time of writing this, Intel was all set to demonstrate its Wireless USB 2.0 technology at the Intel Developer Forum. The technology tows high-speed data



transfer up to 480 Mbps over 4 metres, and up to 110 Mbps over 10 metres. The Bluetooth 1.1 standard can touch 1 Mbps for a distance ranging from 10 to 100 metres, the

speed dropping with distance.

Wireless USB will be based on the multi-band Orthogonal Frequency Division Modulation (OFDM) technology, along with the Ultra-Wide Band (UWB) radio platform defined by the WiMedia alliance.

Cameras, camcorders and MP3 players are also not too happy with the slow transfer speeds offered by current Bluetooth implementations; an area that analysts clearly see the Intel-backed wireless initiative take advantage of.

Intel follows AMD's lead

Intel is all set to follow in AMD's footsteps by bringing 64-bit extensions to both its 32-bit server chips (Xeon) and desktop processors (Prescott). Code-named Nocona, the Xeons will support PCI Express, DDR2 memory, the 64-bit extensions and SSE3.

Nocona chips for two-

processor servers will arrive in the second quarter of 2004, said CEO Craig Barrett, followed by Prescott processors with 32 and 64-bit capability for single-processor servers and workstations. Prescott and Nocona are functionally the same, but differ in cache size and bus speed.

Meanwhile, AMD is ready to put some money to its mouth, and shout from the rooftops that the Intel move is a validation of its claims: The future is x86-64. Intel's 64-bit extensions will be 100 per cent compatible with AMD's—save a few extensions to allow for extra registers, etc.

heroes

64-bit computing
Microsoft has released a public preview of the 64-bit Windows XP for 64-bit Extended Systems, signaling a release later this year. *UT2004* will also feature 64-bit support. Intel also plans to release a 64-bit version of their server-targeted Xeon.

Home Networks
Intel and Microsoft, along with Canon and BEA Systems, are working on standardising the Web services protocol called WS-Discovery that will let all sorts of home media devices interconnect, forming an ad-hoc network.

zeroes

Linux security
UK Security firm, mi2g, analysed 17,074 successful digital-hacker attacks and found Linux servers accounted for 13,654 breaches. BSD and Mac OS X were at the bottom of the list with 555 successful attacks. Windows systems accounted for 2,005 attacks.

DVD-copying software
A San Francisco District Court judge ordered 321 Studios to withdraw all copies of their product and make changes to their controversial DVD-copying products. This would prevent users from using the descrambling tool to duplicate copy-protected DVD movies.

snapshot

NASA's Web site received 6.5 billion page views since January 2004 due to the Mars mission

Source: NASA

■ FBI to place piracy-warning seals on all audio and video media sold ■ Microsoft to ship Windows security updates CDs at no charge